History & Evolution of Design Thinking

A Journey from Systematic Methods to Human-Centric Innovation

Presented for CareerTIQ Training Series

careertiq

A CENTURY OF EVOLUTION

1960s
Design Science & Systematic Methods

1970s
Cognitive Approaches & Wicked Problems

1990s
IDEO & Empathic Commercialization

2000s
Stanford d.school Standardization

Present
Global Strategic Imperative

Phase 1:
The Scientific Roots

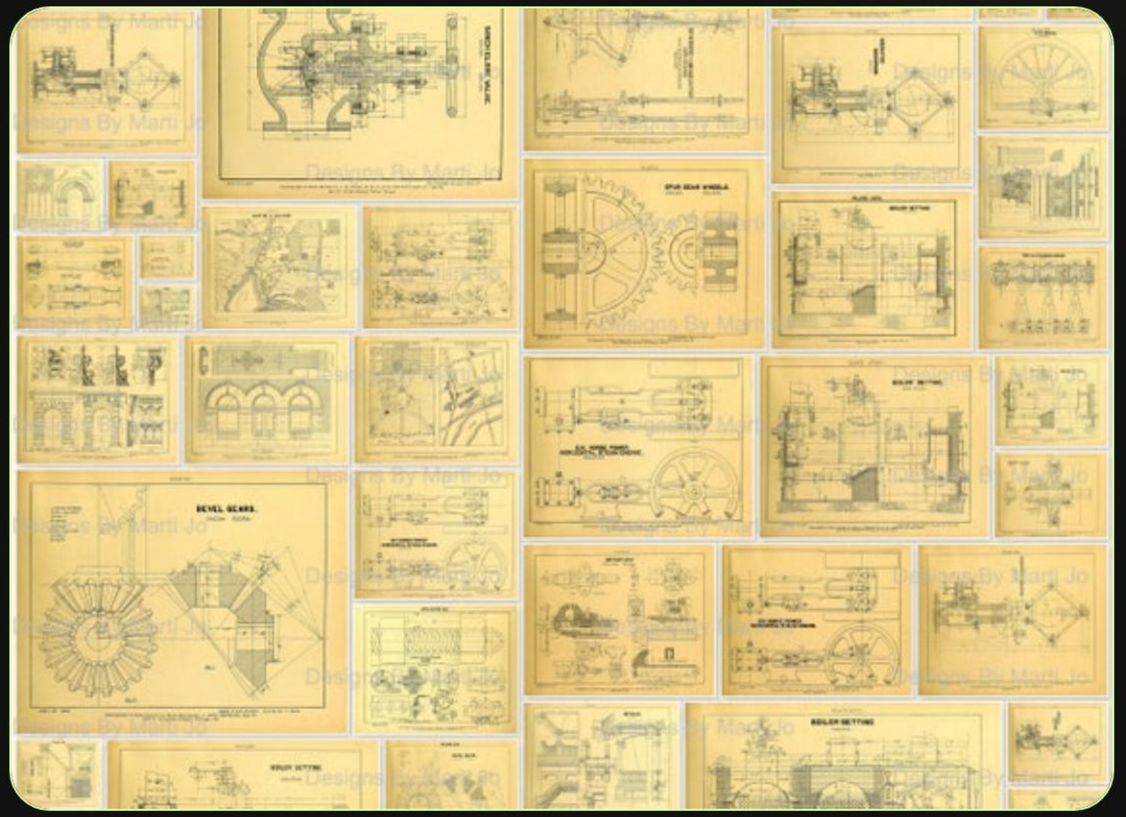
Where logic and systemization met creativity.

THE 1960S DESIGN SCIENCE

Systematic Methods

In this era, pioneers like L. Bruce Archer attempted to make design "scientific." The goal was to remove intuition and replace it with rational, repeatable logic.

Example: NASA's early systems engineering utilized these rigorous design steps to ensure mission success under extreme constraints.



1969: THE COGNITIVE PIVOT

1969

Herbert Simon's Legacy

In his seminal work *"The Sciences of the Artificial,"* Nobel Laureate Herbert Simon defined design not as a craft, but as a "way of thinking."

He introduced core concepts we use today: **Rapid Prototyping** and **Observation**. This moved the focus from the "what" to the "how" of solving complex problems.

SCIENCE VS. DESIGN THINKING

Attribute	Traditional Science	Design Thinking
Goal	Analysis & Truth Discovery	Synthesis & Solution Creation
Problem Type	Well-defined Problems	"Wicked" (Amorphous) Problems
Core Driver	Objectivity & Logic	Empathy & Human Needs
Outcome	Proof / Validation	Prototypes / Innovation

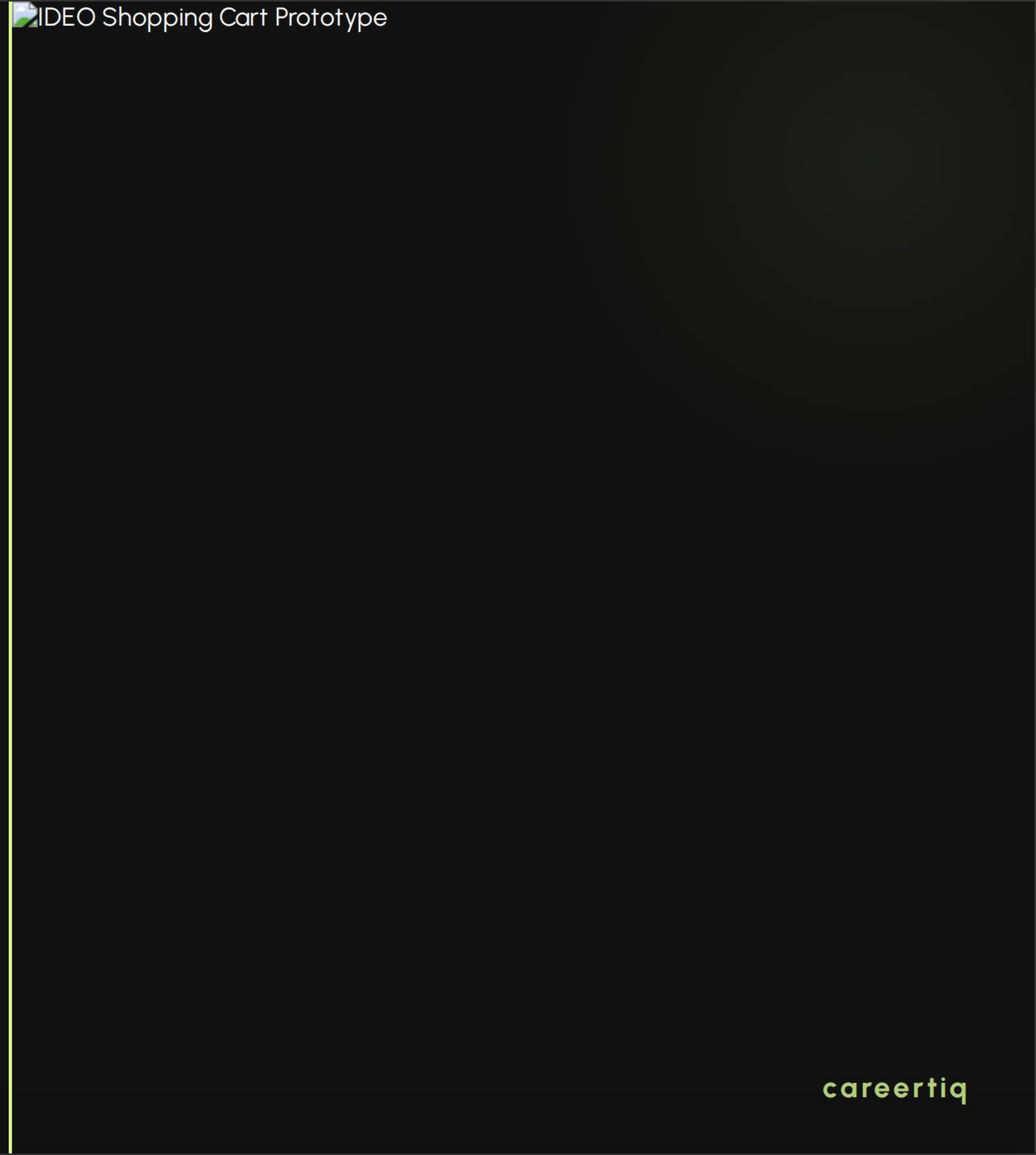
Phase 2:
IDEO & Empathy

Bringing design thinking into the boardroom.

THE SHOPPING CART

In 1999, ABC News challenged IDEO to redesign the shopping cart in 5 days. This became the definitive "proof of concept" for Design Thinking.

The Example: Instead of focusing on the cart's structure, the team observed parents and store employees. They created a cart that focused on **safety, maneuverability, and modularity**.



STANDARDIZING STANFORD



The d.school Impact

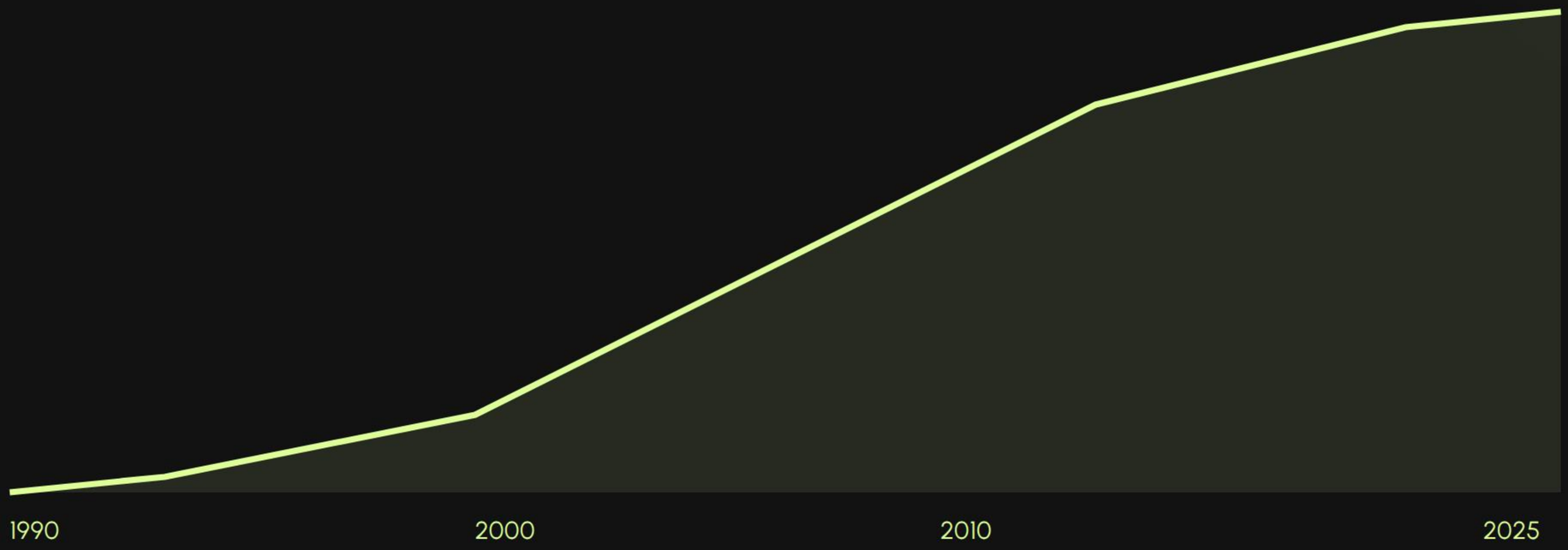
Founded in 2005 by David Kelley, the Hasso Plattner Institute of Design (d.school) turned Design Thinking into a formal 5-step curriculum.



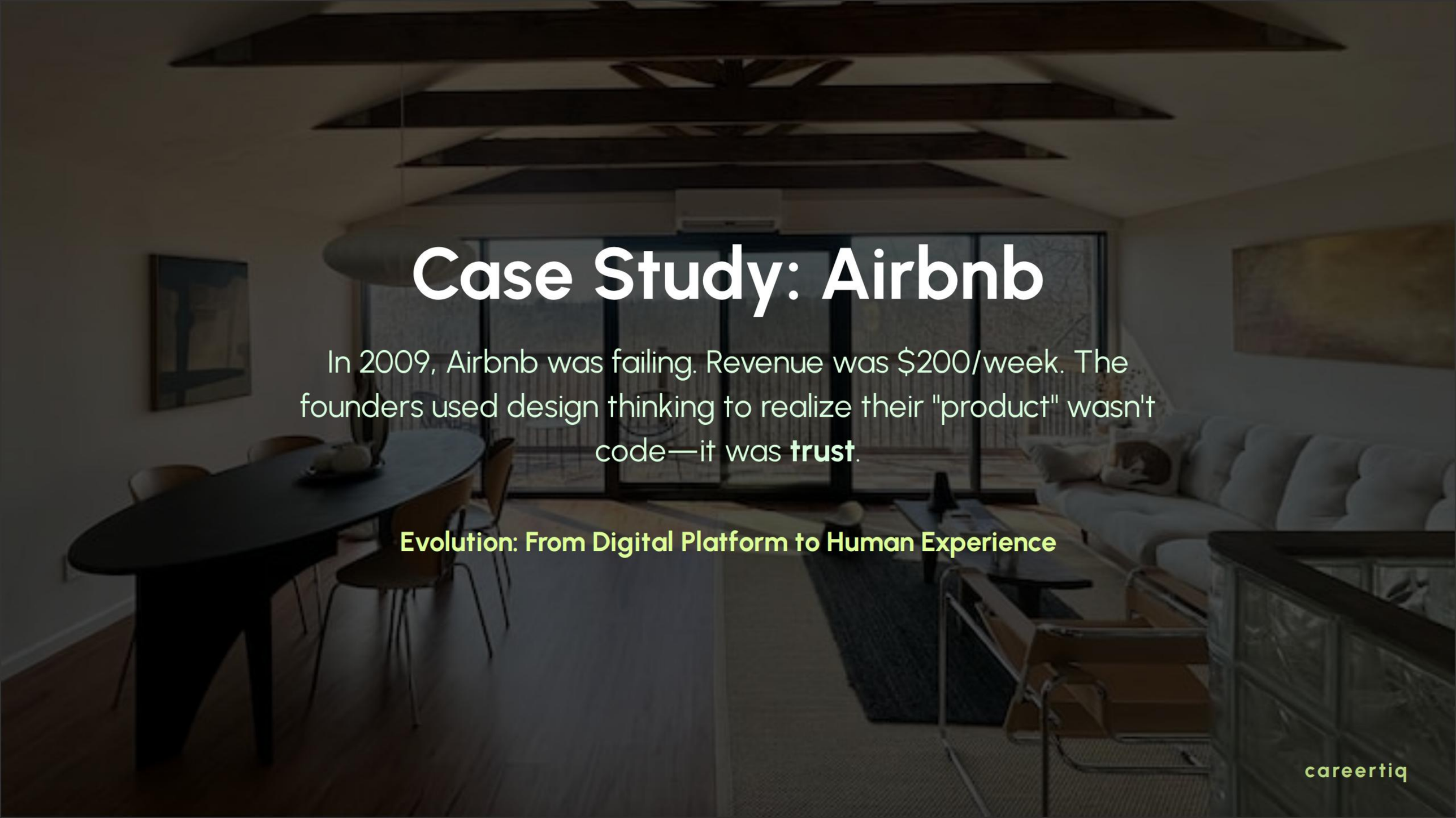
Iterative Learning

It popularized the "Empathize, Define, Ideate, Prototype, Test" model, making the process accessible to non-designers globally.

ADOPTION & GROWTH



Shift from Niche Design Tool to Global Business Strategy Metric



Case Study: Airbnb

In 2009, Airbnb was failing. Revenue was $200/week. The founders used design thinking to realize their "product" wasn't code—it was **trust**.

Evolution: From Digital Platform to Human Experience

Questions?

The evolution continues with **You**.

careertiq

Mastering the Art of Modern Problem Solving

IMAGE SOURCES



https://i.etsystatic.com/20009534/r/il/a3f7ac/3012832625/il_570xN.3012832625_79en.jpg

Source: www.etsy.com



https://i.ytimg.com/vi/nysS-4NtY1I/maxresdefault.jpg

Source: www.youtube.com



https://a0.muscache.com/im/pictures/hosting/Hosting-1369165575168204394/original/228a8ddb-2c06-40d0-9321-a8cc7814c733.jpeg?im_w=720

Source: www.airbnb.com